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The fire has burned low, the cedar planks of the longhouse glow amber. The Elder pulls a woven blanket tighter around her shoulders, her voice carrying the weight of uncounted winters. The children lean in. The story begins.

Chapter One: The Time When Animals Were People

In the beginning, the world was not hard. It was soft, like mud before it is fired, like a song before it is sung. There was no lake, no rivers, no islands, only a great dreaming mist that covered everything. And in this mist lived the First People—only they were not people as we are now. They were Animals, and they walked on two legs, and they spoke a single language that all could understand.

Raven was the one who brought the light. He was black as a moonless night, clever and vain, always hungry for something he did not yet possess. At that time, the sun was locked in a cedar box in the house of a greedy chief who lived at the edge of the sky. The chief hoarded the light, so the world was dim and cold, and the Animals stumbled over each other in the greyness.

Raven transformed himself into a hemlock needle, small and sharp. He floated down the river the chief's daughter drank from, and when she swallowed the needle, Raven grew inside her as a child. He was born with black hair and eyes too knowing for an infant. The chief, his grandfather, doted on him and refused him nothing. Raven cried and cried, pointing at the cedar box, until the old man opened it just a crack to let the child play with the glowing ball inside. In that instant, Raven seized the sun in his beak and burst through the smoke hole, his feathers scorched to an iridescent sheen that still shimmers today. He flung the sun into the sky, and light fell upon the world for the first time, revealing its shape.

And what a shape it was. The mist burned away to show a great basin cupped by mountains, laced with silver threads of running water. There were forests of cedar and fir so tall they scratched the belly of the sky. There were meadows of camas and bitterroot. And there, in the deepest hollow of the basin, was a vast emptiness—a dry depression lined with cracked clay and ancient bones.

This emptiness was Coyote's doing. Coyote was the trickster, the fool, the wise one, the one who made mistakes so we could learn from them. He had been racing across the land, chasing his own tail for no reason but the joy of it, when he tripped over a great serpent sunning itself on a rock. Coyote fell hard, his paws gouging deep furrows in the earth. Where his claws scraped, the three great rivers were born: the Tannaron, rushing north; the Silt-Laden, oozing south; the Straight, flowing east. But the deepest hollow, where his belly had slammed the ground, remained empty. Coyote looked at it and laughed. "I will leave this hole," he said, "so that when the rains come, I can see my own handsome face reflected back at me."

The rains did come. They came for forty days and forty nights, not from any god's anger but from

the tears of the Rainbow Serpent, an immense being who lived beneath the earth. She was older than Raven, older than Coyote, older than the oldest rock. She had seen the world born and had coiled through its foundations, holding the continents together with her body. When she felt Coyote's fall, it bruised her back, and she wept in pain and sorrow. Her tears filled the great hollow, and the lake was born. We call it Kitchi-gami, the Great Water, though others would come later with their own names.

The Rainbow Serpent did not die. She settled into the depths, her scales shimmering through the water, and she wept softer tears of joy, for she saw that this lake would be a gathering place. Every river that flowed in carried a story; every shore that touched the water held a different people. She breathed gently, and her breath became the currents that circle the lake to this day. Her ribs, arched and ancient, became the blackened posts you see in the ghost harbour—though that name would not be spoken for many, many generations.

After the lake was filled, the Old Ones came. They arrived in boats so large they could swallow a whole orca, their hulls carved from trees that no longer grow on this earth. Their faces were like ours, but their eyes held the light of distant stars. They did not come to conquer; they came to trade. They taught our ancestors, the Kenosee, how to carve the red cedar with respect, asking the tree's permission before the first cut. They taught us to read the salmon's return by the song of the thrush, and to navigate the lake by the pattern of the waves, singing the water roads so we would never lose our way. They stayed for a season, or perhaps for a century—time moved differently then—and then they sailed away. Some say they returned to the stars. Others say they sank deliberately into the lake, becoming the posts, the ghost harbour, their eternal bones holding up the water so the Rainbow Serpent would not be alone.

And when they were gone, the Animals began their transformation. One by one, they shed their two-legged forms. Bear put on his heavy fur coat and went into the mountains. Salmon dove into the rivers and exchanged his voice for silver scales. Eagle stretched his arms into wings and took the sky. Only Human remained, naked and shivering and unsure. Coyote looked at Human and felt something he had never felt before: pity, mixed with a strange, fierce love. "You are the youngest and the weakest," Coyote said. "You have no fur, no fangs, no wings. But I will give you a gift. I will give you the ability to tell stories. So long as you remember the time when Animals were People, you will never truly be alone. The stories will be your fur, your fangs, your wings. Guard them well."

And then Coyote trotted off into the hills, where he still wanders, sometimes causing trouble, sometimes teaching lessons, always chasing his tail.

Human stood on the shore of the new lake and looked at his reflection. For the first time, he saw his own face. He began to speak, and the words came out as a song, a song of thanks to Raven for the light, to Coyote for the land, to the Rainbow Serpent for the water, to the Old Ones for their teaching. That song is still sung by the Kenosee people. It is the first story in the Unseen Mother's Ledger,

Kenosee, Gondaran, Khalidi, Yehudi, and the *gens du lac*. It records that we are all métis now, mixed in blood, tangled in story, impossible to separate. The final page has not been written, and it never will be, because the story continues with every child born on the shore. But the title of this chapter is known: *The Lake Remembers Everything.*

And Coyote? Coyote is still in the hills, still causing trouble, still chasing his tail. Sometimes, on a winter night when the fire is low and the children are listening, he creeps down to the longhouse door and listens to the stories we tell. He hears his own name, his own foolishness, his own wisdom. And he laughs—a sharp, yipping laugh that echoes across the water. The lights in the ghost harbour flicker in response. The Old Ones are listening, too.

This is the story of mankind, child. Not a straight line but a circle, drawn by a paddle in the water. The ripples spread, touch every shore, and return. The lake sings the rest. Listen. Do you hear it?

The Elder falls silent. The fire has burned to embers. The children, wrapped in blankets, stare at the glowing coals, their minds full of hummingbirds and scorpions, of iron keys and Torah scrolls, of spies and midwives and a serpent weeping under the water. Outside, the lake laps gently against the shore, patient and eternal, carrying the story forward into another night.

coffee and pressed into service by a hollow-chested BSI man named Drummond, code-named CARDAMOM. He hated it, but the prison threat was real. Lydia Orlova, the Aethyrian *rezident*, drank sweet tea in the Café of Exile and left generous tips, her eyes missing nothing. The Unseen Mother's house—now Mama Esi's—was visited by both sides, offering clinics and scholarships, demanding loyalty. Mama Esi refused them all. "The child comes into the world without a flag," she said. "I will not give it one before its first breath."

The desert island's venom was milked for weapons. The Arunta-Ka, resisting the Veridian ochre mines with the Red Hand movement, took guns from the Aethyrians and then poisoned an Aethyrian courier with a dime-spider, declaring neutrality. The world teetered on the edge of a fire that would consume everything, and through it all, the lake remained cold, deep, and indifferent. The ghost harbour lights glowed a little brighter on the nights when a defector swam for the shore, or when a courier's heart gave out wading to Post 17. The Unseen Mother—now a spirit, a principle, a name whispered by midwives—recorded the deaths of spies with the simple annotation: *A man of the lake, nationality uncertain.*

Chapter Nine: The Return of the Old Ones' Lights

The Two Eagles exhausted themselves. The Aethyrian Union, that vast and terrified machine, cracked along the seams of its sixty-seven captive nations. The Tatars reclaimed their language. The Tundrics reclaimed their reindeer routes. The Yehudi emigration, once a trickle of refuseniks, became a flood as the gates opened. Some paused in Three-Mouth on their way to Zion-Jebus, weeping in the *Beth El* synagogue, touching the Torah scroll that Reb Dovid had carried across the ocean so many decades before. Yousef's café served them coffee, his iron key still hanging behind the counter, a silent witness to a wound that might never fully heal.

The Square-Makers' grid is cracking. The courthouse roof leaks. The *Sentinel* has shrunk to a single page of advertisements. The Dawes house still stands empty, its widow's walk staring at the water, a monument to a dream that died. The baobab in Little Asante-Mossi has grown tall enough to shade a whole courtyard. The Temple of the Living Waters baptizes in the lake, and their children swim alongside the *gens du lac* children, the Khalidi children, the Yehudi children, all in the same water, all under the same sky.

The ghost harbour glows brighter than ever. The Arunta-Ka on Ularu-Ma have driven out the mining company, reclaiming the red mother island with song and sabotage. The Lake Assembly meets every year on the salt pan, drawing exiles from every shore. The Emerald Shard still guards the bones of our ancestors. The Old Man still sleeps on Owa-ka-tawa, his nightmares frozen into the glacier. The Rainbow Serpent still breathes in the depths, her ribs holding up the water.

The Unseen Mother's Ledger is now a library, kept by a circle of midwives from five traditions—

recorded not on paper but in the living memory of the midwives, passed from hand to hand, voice to voice, across all the winters that would follow.

This was the Time When Animals Were People, the time before the Long Balance, before the Boat People, before the Square-Makers and the shadow wars. It is the foundation, the deep bedrock. Remember it, child. Every story that follows is built on this one.

Chapter Two: The First People and the Long Balance

From the red stone of the scarp, we emerged. The Kenosee. Our name means "the people of the rising stone," for we were shaped from the limestone cliffs that the Aedesians would later call the Terrace, though we called it Misko-waapikaan. The lake was our mother, the rivers our brothers, the islands our aunts and uncles. We were not alone. On the great arid island, Ularu-Ma, the red mother, lived our cousins the Arunta-Ka. They had been placed there by the Rainbow Serpent to learn the secrets of the desert—how to find water in the salt pans, how to sing the venom out of a scorpion's sting, how to read the stories written in the red ochre. We visited each other by canoe, paddling songs into the water so the currents would carry us safely.

The Emerald Shard, the green island covered in cloud forest and orchids, was our medicine garden. Only the healers and the midwives could land there, gathering herbs that cured fever, eased childbirth, opened the mind to visions. The hummingbirds that filled its air were our messengers, carrying whispers from one shore to the other on wings too fast to see. We buried our dead there, laying their bones among the moss and flowers, so their spirits would become part of the island's green memory, forever blooming.

Owa-ka-tawa, the snowy peak, was where the Old Man slept. He was not a man but a mountain spirit, ancient and dreaming. His dreams froze as they left his mind, coating the peak in a white blanket that never melted, even in the hottest summer. We did not climb that mountain. To disturb the Old Man's sleep would be to invite his nightmares into the world. We left offerings at its base—dried fish, baskets of berries—and listened to his snoring in the winter winds.

For uncounted generations, we lived in the Long Balance. Our laws were not written on paper but carved into story poles, tall cedars with the faces of our ancestors staring out, reminding us of our debts to the past. Our wars were small, disputes over fishing grounds or marriage promises, and they ended not with annihilation but with ceremony, the losing side gifting blankets and songs to the victors. Our winter villages were by the lake, our summer camps in the hills, following the rhythm of the salmon, the deer, the berries. We were not a perfect people—we had greed, jealousy, cruelty—but the Long Balance held, because the stories held, because Coyote would shame the greedy and Raven would steal from the cruel, because the Unseen Mother walked among us.

The Unseen Mother. She was not the first. There had been midwives before her, a line stretching back to the time of the Old Ones. But she was the one who began the Ledger. She was a small woman, unremarkable in appearance, with hands that knew the exact pressure to turn a breech baby or to calm a panicked mother. She never married, though she delivered enough children to populate a hundred villages. She lived in a small house on the Ridge, where the Shanty Quarter would later grow, and she stitched the genealogies of our people onto deer hide with sinew from the lake sturgeon. Every birth, she recorded. Every death. Every marriage, every adoption, every lost child found again. The Ledger was not a book but a living thing, added to with each generation, its pages soft and worn, smelling of smoke and herbs and the faint iron tang of birthing blood.

The Unseen Mother was called “unseen” because she moved through the world without leaving footprints, without raising her voice. She attended births in Kenosee longhouses, Arunta-Ka desert camps, even—in later years—the houses of the Boat People, who never understood her but respected her skill. She knew the secrets of every family, the hidden adoptions, the affairs, the children born of violence and the children born of love. She told no one. The Ledger was her confessor, and she guarded it with her life.

In the Long Balance, she recorded only our own people. But that would change. The first strange ship was coming, and the Ledger would swell to hold the whole world.

Chapter Three: The Coming of the Boat People and the First Rift

The first sign was a smell. The fishermen noticed it first: a strange, sour tang on the wind, mixed with the familiar salt of the lake. Then a shape appeared on the eastern horizon, where the Straight River meets the sky. It was not a canoe. It was a floating island of wood and cloth, with white wings that caught the wind and a belly full of men.

The men who stepped onto our shore had faces covered in matted hair, like moss hanging from a dying tree. Their skin was pale as a salmon’s belly, and their eyes were the colour of shallow water over sand. They wore heavy clothes that stank of iron and sweat, and they carried long sticks that coughed thunder and killed at a distance. We called them the Boat People, and later we learned they called themselves Aedesians.

Their leader was a man named Mawbray. He had the eyes of a hungry wolf, always scanning, measuring, calculating. He planted a metal pole in our earth with a cloth hanging from it—red, with a serpent in the centre—and spoke words in his barking language that meant the lake now belonged to a King across the water, a man who had never seen this shore, whose name we could not pronounce. Coyote would have laughed. But Coyote was in the hills, and we were standing on the shore, watching the future arrive.

tradition with the lake’s own mystery. Its congregation believed the ghost harbour was the Heavenly Jerusalem, lowered into the water by angels to protect it from colonial desecration. They baptized their children in the lake, the same water that had received the tears of the Rainbow Serpent, the bones of the Old Ones, the bodies of drowned fugitives. Mama Esi, a Gondaran midwife, became the Unseen Mother’s hands while the old woman retreated into myth. She knew the herbs of the cloud forest, the pressure points for a breech birth, the songs to sing over a newborn so they would know their ancestors’ names.

The Gondarans worked the grain elevators, the railroads, the garment workshops. They sent money home through the Veridian Postal Money Order system, each transaction shaving a fee that ended up in a Graniteburg bank. Some of the young men, frustrated and angry, were recruited by shadowy Veridian companies to work as strikebreakers or to return to Gondarah as overseers—a bitter cycle of dependency that independence had not broken. But the Lake Assembly, that gathering of exiles on the desert island’s salt pan, began to meet in 1954. Gondarans, Khalidis, Arunta-Ka, *gens du lac*—all the displaced pieces of the world, sharing food, strategies, and prophecies under the same stars that had watched the ghost harbour rise and sink. The Unseen Mother, it is said, attended the first one, carried on a litter by Mama Esi’s sons. She said nothing, just watched, and smiled.

Chapter Eight: The Shadow Game of the Two Eagles

The old empires rotted away. The Aedesians and Vhurians were ghosts now, their flags patched and faded, their power reduced to a cultural lecture and a leaky trawler. From their ashes rose two new Eagles, vast and predatory, who glared at each other across the world.

The Eagle of the West was the Commonwealth of Veridia, now a superpower with bombs that could crack the planet. The Eagle of the East was the Aethyrian Federated Socialist Republics, born from a revolution that had toppled the Tsardom and built a new cage of concrete and terror. They never fought with open claws on the lake—too many eyes, too many potential fires—but they played a shadow game that seeped into every corner of Three-Mouth.

The Veridian Bureau of Strategic Intelligence set up a station in the courthouse basement, its real name hidden behind a sign that read “Lake Commerce Analysis Office.” The Aethyrian PCSS operated from a fishing trawler anchored near the ghost harbour, its hold stuffed with listening gear and black-market caviar. The snowy island, Owa-ka-tawa, became an ear, its scientific station a cover for a vast antenna array. The ghost harbour posts, those patient bones, became dead drops—Post 17, Post 23, Post 41—where microfilm was exchanged at low water by men in waders. The *gens du lac* knew. They always knew. They charged a toll, payable in cash or information, to ensure the sheriff’s patrols did not accidentally interrupt the trade.

The informants were everywhere. Bashir Abu-Zaydan, Yousef’s son, was caught running Zacate

the Cradle's coast. When the Yehudi settlement company bought his village's land from an absentee landlord, Yousef's family was displaced. He crossed the ocean with his wife, Umm Walid, and their son Bashir, carrying nothing but an iron key to a house that no longer stood, wrapped in a faded deed written in Arabic. He opened the *Ahwa al-Manfa*, the Café of Exile, on the waterfront, serving cardamom coffee from a brass *dallah* and baklava that reminded him of home.

The Yehudi and the Khalidis, locked in a death-grip in the Cradle, became neighbours on the Terrace. Reb Dovid and Yousef nodded at each other across the market square, a wary politeness that the lake wind seemed to soften. Their children played together in the unpaved alleys, fought over a ball, learned each other's curses. The Unseen Mother—now impossibly old, her face a map of wrinkles—learned the Yehudi *brit milah* prayers and the Khalidi *aqiqah* naming ceremony. She added both to the Ledger, along with the births, the deaths, the quiet acts of kindness that passed between the two communities. A Khalidi woman slipped a pot of honey to a sick Yehudi child. A Yehudi carpenter repaired the café's broken door.

But the poison of the Cradle also seeped in. Fundraisers for the National Home came, collecting gold. Khalidi emissaries came, collecting messages. The children fought in the schoolyard, echoing the battles across the sea. The Unseen Mother watched it all and wrote nothing of politics in the Ledger—only the names, only the lives. The lake held its breath, waiting.

Chapter Seven: The Gondaran Diaspora and the Hollow Freedom

The Vhurian empire, exhausted and bankrupt, finally released its grip on Gondarah. The southern continent erupted in a wave of independence movements—the Free Republic of Asante-Mossi, the Union of Oyo-Zambezi, the Saffron Coast Federation. New flags snapped in the wind, new presidents gave speeches about dawn, new anthems were sung. But the old chains were melted down and recast as bank loans. The Aedesians and Vhurians, before lowering their flags, had tied the new nations' currencies to their own dying economies. The cocoa, the copper, the palm oil still flowed north, the prices set in Graniteburg and Aedon, not in the markets of Gondarah. The freedom was a gourd with a hole in the bottom.

And so the Gondarans came. They always come to water. They found their way to Three-Mouth, the magnet for the displaced, the neighbourhood that asked for no papers and promised nothing but a roof and a neighbour. On the Ridge, where the Shanty Quarter sprawled, a new street formed: Little Asante-Mossi, the locals called it, or simply *la Côte*. The houses were clapboard, painted in ochre and indigo, with corrugated roofs that sang in the rain. A baobab sapling, smuggled as a seed in a woman's headwrap, grew in a courtyard beside a shriveled Veridian apple tree—a botanical miracle that everyone accepted without question.

The Temple of the Living Waters rose among them, a church that blended the Gondaran prophetic

At first, we traded. Beaver pelts for iron knives that did not break. Dried fish for that burning water they called rum, which made the young men foolish and the old men angry. We learned some of their words; they learned none of ours. They built square houses on the Terrace, cutting into the red stone of Misko-waapikaan as if trying to carve their name on our grandmother's face. They brought their Holy Book, a collection of stories they insisted was the only true story, and their Land Deed, a piece of paper they claimed gave them the right to the soil. These were two things we could not eat, but they valued them above water, above food, above life itself.

More ships came. The Boat People brought women, pale and frightened, who gave birth in the shadow of the scarp. The Unseen Mother attended them, though they feared her at first, with her dark skin and her silent, knowing hands. She learned their birthing screams sounded the same as ours. She recorded their children in the Ledger, the first non-Kenosee names to stain the deer hide, written in a script she was only just learning.

Then came the coughing sickness. It spread through our longhouses like a ghost, invisible and merciless. Our medicine could not cure it. Our healers fell alongside the children. Whole villages emptied, their story poles left to rot. The Boat People had brought this sickness in their blankets, in their breath, though whether by accident or design, only the dead know for certain. And then came the thunder-sticks, when we resisted their hunger for more land, more furs, more submission. Our warriors, brave as they were, could not outrun the lead.

The Long Balance cracked. Not with a single blow, but like ice in a warm wind. The Boat People called it "civilization." We called it the First Rift. The world was dividing, and the lake was at the centre of the fracture.

Chapter Four: The River Divisions and the Three Continents

The Boat People were not a single tribe, though they looked the same to us. They quarrelled like gulls over a washed-up salmon. From the south came the Vhurians, a people from a sinking land across the ocean. They built their strongholds along the Silt-Laden River delta, not square houses but stone stars with sharp points—fortresses, prisons. And they brought with them a new kind of Boat Person, ones who did not come willingly. These were people with skin of deep night and hands that knew the soil, stolen from a vast, hot continent called Gondarah. The Vhurians put them in chains, worked them on sugar-cane plantations, and called them property. The lake, which had always united us, became a border. The southern shore became the Slave South, a place of misery and resistance, where the enslaved sang songs of liberation in the night, their voices carrying across the water.

The Aedesians claimed the north and west. They called the Tannaron River the boundary of the Sauvage North—a wild, empty place on their maps, though it was our home, filled with our villages,

our memories, our bones. The Straight River was tamed with locks and quays, a highway for more settlers from the rising power to the east, the Veridians. The lake was no longer Kitchi-gami. It was a chessboard, and we were pieces to be moved or removed.

The Kenosee were pushed north, into the Tannaron headwaters. The Treaty was signed with pictograms, our chiefs making marks on paper that the Aedesians assured us meant "perpetual hunting rights." In our oral understanding, we had agreed to share the land, not sell it. The written text, which no Kenosee could read, said otherwise. Within a generation, the hunting rights were abolished. Our reservation was reduced, its boundaries drawn by a surveyor with a ruler. We became strangers on our own ground.

But we did not vanish. The lake has a way of mixing things. The Aedesian traders, lonely and far from their own women, took Kenosee wives. Their children were the *gens du lac*, the Lake People, a new tribe with one foot in the water and one on the shore. They inherited our canoe skills, our knowledge of the ghost harbour, our songs for navigating the currents. They also inherited their fathers' stubbornness and their mothers' resilience. The Unseen Mother saw them born, one by one, and in her mind she gave them a charter: the lake would always have its own nation, a people who belonged not to Aedon or Veridia or Zacate, but to the water itself. That charter was never written. It did not need to be. It was stitched into the Ledger, in the sinew that bound the pages.

Chapter Five: The Square-Makers and the Paper War

The Aedesians grew old and weak. Their island kingdom, Aedon, exhausted its mines and forests. They could no longer hold the western continent, and in a series of rebellions, the eastern colonies broke free. They called themselves the Commonwealth of Veridia—the Square-Makers, we named them, for their obsession with straight lines and right angles.

The Square-Makers did not conquer Three-Mouth with an army. They bought it, surveyed it, and renamed it. Land speculators arrived with legal documents that the old Aedesian governor, now a drunkard in his crumbling mansion, could not dispute. They laid down a grid of numbered streets that ignored the curve of the shore, the flow of the creek, the ancient burial mounds. Ghost Apple Road, where the métis families had planted orchards, became 7th Avenue West. The Shanty Quarter was carved into lots and sold, often to buyers who never set foot in the neighbourhood. The *gens du lac* found their homes reclassified as "squatters' claims," their ancestral charter dismissed as a primitive myth.

The courthouse rose, whitewashed brick with Doric columns, a temple to the Paper God. The *Three-Mouth Sentinel* began printing, its pages telling the history of the place as if nothing had existed before the first Veridian sawmill. The racial codes arrived, lumping all of us—Kenosee, métis, *gens du lac*, the few Arunta-Ka who had crossed the water—into a single category: "colored." Our

children were sent to separate schools, our dead to separate cemeteries, our souls to a separate heaven, if the Veridian missionaries were to be believed.

Yet, the Square-Makers brought a peculiar chaos. They could not agree among themselves about the owning of people. Their southern states held millions of Gondaran descendants in bondage; their northern states called it an abomination. The war came, a great tearing that stained their own soil with blood. And during that war, the lake became a road of liberation. Runaways from the Veridian south fled north, guided by the *gens du lac* pilots, hidden in the Shanty Quarter, ferried across the water to Zacate, where slavery had been abolished decades before by the revolutionary Tecún. The ghost harbour lights, those patient blue glimmers, guided the midnight canoes. The Unseen Mother added the names of the fugitives to the Ledger, encoded in a script only the midwives could read. Some made it. Some were caught. Some drowned. All were recorded.

The Dawes family, that unlucky Veridian clan, built their grand house on the Terrace, claiming the waterfront as their own. They fought the *gens du lac* in the courts for three generations, winning every paper battle but losing the true war. The lake did not recognize their deeds. The ghost harbour posts still rose every spring, older than any Veridian claim. And when the last Dawes died, childless, she left the house to "the People of the Lake, as represented by the Unseen Mother"—a title no court could enforce but every neighbour respected. The house stood empty, a monument to the failure of a certain kind of dream.

Chapter Six: The Exiles from the Cradle

The world beyond the lake was bleeding. Far to the east, in a land the Aedesians called the Cradle of Prophets, a holy city was being torn apart. Zion-Jebus, the city of three faiths, had been under the rule of a great Sultanate for centuries. When the Sultanate collapsed, the Aedesians carved up the Cradle with a ruler, promising a national home to the Yehudi people while ignoring the Khalidi farmers who had tilled the olive groves for a thousand years. The wound festered, and its poison spread across the ocean.

The Yehudi came first. They were fleeing pogroms in the Tsardom of Aethyria, a vast, cold empire where mobs burned their villages and the state looked the other way. They arrived in Three-Mouth with nothing but brass samovars, Torah scrolls wrapped in velvet, and a look of haunted relief. They converted a fur warehouse on the Terrace's edge into the *Beth El of the Lake* synagogue, their singing floating out over the market square, a strange, minor-key music that made the Veridian Protestants uneasy. Reb Dovid, their rabbi, was a small man with a beard like white smoke and eyes that had seen too much. He had lost a wife and two daughters to the Tsar's Cossacks. He spoke little, but when he chanted the ancient prayers, his voice shook the rafters.

Then came the Khalidis. Yousef Abu-Zaydan had been an olive-oil merchant in Jaffa-Gate, a port on